conflict. Using theoretical insights provided by feminist political economy, it analyses the material basis for women's support for and involvement in the KIO/KIA.

Recent research (Henshaw 2015; Mazurana 2013; Shekhawat 2015) suggests that women — like men — join armies for ideological and political reasons related to their position as members of a marginalized ethnic and religious group. However, a more careful gender analysis will reveal that women's decisions to participate in or support armed struggle stem from gender-specific experiences of insecurity and oppression. In Kachin State, these gender differences are visible in the high number of female-headed households compared to other areas of Myanmar (Union of Myanmar 2015b); the inability of women to inherit property (KWAT 2014, p. 26); and the deliberate targeting of minority women by Myanmar armed forces, or Tatmadaw, officers and soldiers (Human Rights Watch 2012).

It is important to note that women's exposure to gender-based violence in Myanmar is related to their exclusion from positions of power and influence. This exclusion reflects a gendered division of labour that holds men as the representatives of the collective, as evidenced by the acute lack of women in leadership positions within both the local and the national polity (Minoletti 2014). Oppression based on ethnicity and religion is then experienced through gender identities. It is precisely their gender-specific experiences of physical and material insecurity, including poverty, gender-based violence, and discrimination, which lead women to support or participate in the armed struggle. A feminist political economy analysis renders visible these underlying gendered patterns of conflict, thereby enhancing the prospects for sustainable peace by paying attention to the needs and objectives of Kachin women in general, and female soldiers in particular.

This research was informed by a set of questions aimed at understanding the relationship between gendered insecurity and Kachin women's participation in and support of the military struggle. Believing that women have been silenced in much research on Myanmar, intentionally the majority of the interviewees were women. In total, twenty-five women and one man currently or previously working in key Kachin resistance or civil society organizations were interviewed. These organizations included the Kachin Independence Organisation (KIO), the KIA, the Kachin Women's Association (KWA), the Kachin Women's Association Thailand (KWAT), and the Kachin Women's Union (KWU). In seventeen of the twenty-five cases,